was known for bulldozing through official barricades to achieve my goals, which included the making of India's first big liquid propulsion systems. I also told them that I found the IB interrogation fishy as they came with a story and kept amending the plot as and when I demolished some parts.

The two officers kept taking copious notes. I spoke for hours and it must have been past midnight when I finished. Sharma, for the first time, stood up and offered me a cigarette. I took it. I was at ease with these officers, though exhausted.

Sharma and Nair asked a few questions about my belongings—some home appliances, which I understood they had listed out after a search at my place when I was in custody (later one of them told me that the search yielded nothing suspicious). I gave them a list of things I owned, some of which I had brought back from France.

They asked about my association with the other accused. I told them I knew only Sasi and Chandrasekhar.

'Are you sure?' Sharma asked.

I replied in the affirmative, and he did not ask any more questions that day.

'You may go and take rest,' he said. 'And you need not bother about waking up early, sleep as much as you want. We want you fresh tomorrow.'

I went back to the room and my left hand was again handcuffed to the leg of the cot. Lying there with my hand thus extended gave me a shoulder pain, but the exhaustion took over and I fell asleep.

THE FRENCH CONNECTION

Kanwal Grover stunned everyone at Le Lido, sponsoring half a bottle of champagne to each of the 2,000 guests that night.

Much before Dhawan asked me to look for foreign collaborations, I had initiated it when Sarabhai was alive. Sarabhai, with his global network of contacts, had initiated talks with SEP, a private French company